

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 21: The Land of Israel

Monday August 19 and Tuesday August 20, 2024

Individual emissaries from Eretz Israel (שליחים לעצמם) and letters written for them

Ruth Lamdan, Tel Aviv University

Jerusalem, The National Library of Israel, Ktiv Project, Ms. Heb. 8°61, system no. 990000434660205171, Correspondence from Jerusalem in the 17th Century, letter no. 178, fol. 209-210 (digitized fol. 109-110).

A Reference for a Poor Man¹

[To] the cherished group of nobles,² heroes of old, men of renown³ who clothe themselves with righteousness,⁴ whose name is great,⁵ who seamlessly combine⁶ giving large amounts of charity with providing strength, a fortress of salvation.⁷ [You] pursue righteousness,⁸ supporting every good cause⁹ – people of God, prophets¹⁰ who rejoice at doing what the Creator desires,¹¹ emptying out your sacks

¹ Jerusalem, The National Library of Israel, Ms. Heb. 8°61, letter 178, fol. 209-210 (digitized fol. 109). Minna Rozen mentions it in her Hebrew book *The Jewish Community in Jerusalem in the 17th Century* (Tel Aviv: Tel Aviv University and the Ministry of Defense Press, 1984), p. 19, n. 49. This is one of the only examples in the collection in which the copyist forgot to remove the name of the person bearing the letter.

² Based on Psalms 68:31.

³ Based on Genesis 6:4.

⁴ Based on Job 29:14.

⁵ II Samuel 7:9.

⁶ This phrase, based on Genesis 41:5, is an expression in rabbinic Hebrew to indicate perfect harmony.

⁷ A combination of Isaiah 45:24 and Psalms 28:8.

⁸ Isaiah 51:1.

⁹ Based on Ezekiel 27:9.

¹⁰ Based on Numbers 11:29.

¹¹ Based on the prayer of *Kiddush Levanah* (the monthly blessing of the moon)

daily,¹² neither tiring nor becoming weary.¹³ One act of giving follows another¹⁴ towards the survivors about whom the Lord calls,¹⁵ instructing you to be charitable,¹⁶ to satisfy the longing soul.¹⁷ It is not too difficult for you, and it is not beyond your reach¹⁸ - merciful people from a long line of merciful people, kind people from a long line of kind people.¹⁹ Behold, you are of the groups praising God²⁰ in every city and country, in the places where the edicts of the king – the King of the world – and his laws reach.²¹ On your heads is a crown of glory, for those whom God has carried since birth.²² Behold, you are the perfect sages, the distinguished rabbis – the very best²³ at lighting the lamp of mitzva and Torah²⁴ – followed by all the upright in heart,²⁵ the generous ones of the people, the nation of the God of Abraham,²⁶ their leaders, elders, and guides,²⁷ and all those who work together peacefully for the public good.²⁸ May God grant you long lives forever,²⁹ and may you enjoy an abundance of peace.³⁰ Amen, eternally, selah, forever.

After directing prayers and supplication to the One who dwells on high³¹ asking that you live well and peacefully, we are writing to you on behalf of those who are

¹² Based on Genesis 42:35.

¹³ Based on Isaiah 40:31.

¹⁴ Based on Hosea 4:2, with wordplay. The Hebrew word “*damim*” can mean bloodshed (as in the verse cited דמים נעור, בדמים נער), but it can also mean money, which is how it is used here.

¹⁵ Joel 3:5 (=Joel 2:32 in KJV).

¹⁶ Based on Joel 2:23.

¹⁷ Based on Psalms 107:9.

¹⁸ Based on Deuteronomy 30:11.

¹⁹ Babylonian Talmud, Ketuvot 8b.

²⁰ Based on a combination of Psalms 68:27 and 22:3.

²¹ Based on Esther 4:3.

²² Based on a combination of Isaiah 46:3 and Proverbs 16:31. This four-word phrase appears in *Kiddush Levanah*.

²³ This phrase, borrowed from II Kings 9:13, is an expression in rabbinic Hebrew to indicate the highest or very best.

²⁴ Based on Proverbs 6:23.

²⁵ Based on Psalms 32:11.

²⁶ Based on Psalms 47:10.

²⁷ Based on Deuteronomy 29:9.

²⁸ Based on Psalms 4:9.

²⁹ Based on Isaiah 38:16.

³⁰ Based on Psalms 37:11.

³¹ Based on the *Chasal Siddur Pesach* prayer found in the Passover Haggadah.

weeping as they walk³² due to all the hardships that we have been through³³ which were rampant in the city of God on account of a foreign king and his officers who eat us alive. Not a minute goes by without a blow, and we can bear Israel's misery no longer.³⁴ [And the] honorable people who come from the ends of the earth because they desire³⁵ to live well in our Land³⁶ - which is the mother of all life³⁷ and protects the path to the tree of life³⁸ - their sacks were emptied before they reached their desired haven.³⁹ A smoking oven and a flaming torch⁴⁰ burned in their midst, for they were stripped of all their goods, unable to bring home food, and they are crying and bewildered about what has happened.⁴¹

Such is the case with this poor man, suffering and gaunt, the esteemed Rabbi David, who bears this letter. He was living serenely in his home and flourishing in his palace,⁴² and all his soul desired was to gaze on the beauty of the Lord and to visit His Temple,⁴³ and in the course of mere days he was stripped of everything he had, [leaving] a millstone around his neck.⁴⁴ And his anguish is even greater on account of his daughters: for three things ~~the earth~~ his soul trembles,⁴⁵ for they have matured and reached marriageable age, yet his home has nothing. There is no

³² A combination of II Samuel 3:16 and Psalms 126:6.

³³ Based on Numbers 20:14.

³⁴ Based on Judges 10:16

³⁵ Based on Deuteronomy 12:20.

³⁶ Based on Psalms 85:10.

³⁷ Based on Genesis 3:20.

³⁸ Genesis 3:24.

³⁹ Based on Psalms 107:30.

⁴⁰ Based on Genesis 16:17.

⁴¹ Based on Ecclesiastes 2:12.

⁴² Based on Daniel 4:1 (=KJV 4:4).

⁴³ Based on Psalms 27:4.

⁴⁴ Based on Babylonian Talmud, Kiddushin 29b.

⁴⁵ Based on Proverbs 30:21. The scribe originally wrote "make the earth tremble," which is the correct conclusion to the verse cited, but then crossed it out and wrote "his soul" instead in accordance with the context. The word "three" is marked in the original to indicate that the supplicant had three daughters.

food and there is no clothing,⁴⁶ and he weeps and wails for his family [למספחותיו]⁴⁷, sighing endlessly.

Therefore, we are full of sorrow for this poor man, because as we have heard he was among the givers and not the takers, but now everything has reversed, due to the unbelievable terrors of the time, and he has been forced to leave his home, and to knock on the doors and gates of those who have been blessed by God. May they transfer some of their bounty to his pocket, to bandage his wounds and repair the breaches of the house of David,⁴⁸ which are many.

Therefore, we have come to beseech your honors to strengthen the feeble hands and steady the buckling knees,⁴⁹ for it is a time for you to act for God,⁵⁰ [. . .] especially for this poor man, who has a mask of embarrassment hovering over his face⁵¹, and he lacks the words to beg, as he has no experience with this.⁵² Therefore we said: Let us speak up for those who are mute,⁵³ and we have come in these two lines to vouch for him before your honors with all your charity [. . .]. Now it is your mitzva, you priests [Cohens?], to support him and bring him joy, to fill him with maximum happiness⁵⁴ with valuable money. [. . .] So that he can return, appearing on the mountain of God,⁵⁵ to take care of the members of his household, all of whom are directing their eyes toward His providence (may He be blessed). As a reward for this, behold, our God⁵⁶ stands watching behind our wall⁵⁷ to bring blessing to your storehouses.⁵⁸ May He send you help from the holy place and

⁴⁶ Based on Isaiah 3:7.

⁴⁷ Based on Numeri 10:11. A change of one letter in Hebrew means: his **troubles**, instead: of his **family**.

⁴⁸ Based on Isaiah 22:9. A clever play on words, as the supplicant's name is David.

⁴⁹ Based on Isaiah 35:3.

⁵⁰ Based on Psalms 119:126

⁵¹ Based on Genesis 1:2, instead of: "and the Spirit of God was hovering over the waters".

⁵² Based on I Samuel 17:39.

⁵³ Based on Proverbs 31:8.

⁵⁴ Based on Psalms 16:11.

⁵⁵ Based on Genesis 22:14.

⁵⁶ Isaiah 25:9.

⁵⁷ Based on Song of Songs 2:9.

⁵⁸ A combination of Ezekiel 44:30 and Deuteronomy 28:8.

grant you support from Zion.⁵⁹ May your eyes see Jerusalem [restored as] a peaceful abode,⁶⁰ and the palace standing in its proper place.⁶¹

⁵⁹ Based on Psalms 20:3 (=KJV 20:2).

⁶⁰ Based on Isaiah 33:20.

⁶¹ Based on Jeremiah 30:18.

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מליצה [=המליצה] לאיש עני

חמדת עדת אבירים המה הגבורים אשר מעולם, אנשי השם, צדק לבשו וילבשם, כשם הגדולים המגדילים צדקות ועוז ומעוז ישועות בקנה א' [חד] עולות, רודפי צדק מחזיקי כל בדק, עם ה' נביאים ששים ושמחים לעשות רצון קוניהם, יום יום מריקים שקיהם, לא ייעפו לא ייגעו, דמים בדמים⁶² נגעו, השרידים אשר ה' קורא ומורה לצדקה להשביע נפש שוקקה, לא נפלאה מהם ולא רחוקה, רחמנים בני רחמנים גומלי חסדים בני גומלי חסדים, הנה הנם מקהלות תהלות ישראל יי בכל עיר ועיר מדינה ומדינה, מקום אשר דבר המלך מלכו של עולם ודתו [=במשמעות חוקיו] מגיע, ועל ראשיהם מלמעלה עטרת תפארת לעמוסי בטן, ה"ה [הלא הם] החכמי' [ם] השלמים הרבנים המצויינים על גרם המעלות להעלות נר מצוה ותורה, ואחריהם כל ישרי לב נדיבי עמים עם אלד' אברהם, ראשיהם זקניהם ומנהיגיהם וכל העוסקים עם הצבור בשלום יחדו, ה' עליהם יחיו ארך ימים עולם ועד ויתענגו על רוב שלום אנס'ו [אמן נצח סלה ועד].

מאחר עלות כל תפלה כל תחנה לפני שוכן מעונה בעד שלותכם וטובתכם אותותינו אלה בלכתם ילכו הלך ובכה על כל התלאה אשר מצא ורבעה בעיר האלד'ים מחמת מלך ושרים זרים אוכלים אותנו בכל פה, אין רגע בלי נגע ותקצר נפשו בעמל ישראל, בני מלכים הבאים מקצוי ארץ באות נפשם לשכון

בעברית המילה 'דם', וברבים 'דמים', משמעותה גם דם וגם כסף⁶².

כבוד בארצנו, היא היתה אם כל חי, לשמור את דרך עץ החיים. ויהי הם מריקים שקיהם עד הגיעם למחוז חפצם והנה תנור עשן ולפיד אש בוער בקרבם על כי יצאו נקיים מנכסיהם ואין לאל ידם להביא טרף לביתם והמה בוכים ותוהים על אשר כבר עשוהו, כאשר קרה לעני הלזה, כואב ורזה, כה"ר דוד וכו', מוביל כתבא דנא. שליו היה בביתו ורענן בהיכלו ונפשו אֹתה לחזות בנעם ה' ולבקר בהיכלו, ובתוך ימים מועטים נשאר קרח מכל אשר לו, כי רחיים על צוארו, ונוסף יגון על יגונותיו צרת הבנות בנותיו, תחת שלש רגזה הארץ [מחוק בקו במקור] נפשו, כי בגרו הגיעו לפרקן וביתו ריקן אין לחם ואין שמלה ובקול יללה בוכה למספחותיו כי רבות אנחותיו. אשר ע"כ [על כן] עגמה נפשנו לאביון כי כפי הנשמע היה מן הנותנים ולא מן המקבלים, ועתה ה[ת]הפך עליו בלהות הזמן בלתי נאמן והוכרח לצאת ממחיצתו לדפוק על דלתי שערי בריחי ברוכי ה' יטילו מלאם לכיסו לחבוש נגעי מכותיו ואת בקיעי בית דוד כי רבו.

לכן אתאנו לחלות פני מעכ"ת [מעלת כבוד תורתכם] חזקו ידיים רפות וברכים כושלות אמצו כי עת לעשות לה' [...] כ"ש [כל שכן] לאיש עני כזה אשר מסוה הבושה מרחפת על פניו ואין מלה בלשונו לשאול ולדרוש כי לא נסה באלה. ע"כ אמרנו פתח פיך לאלם ובאנו בשתי שורות אלו להליץ עליו לפני מעכ"ת ככל צדקותיכם [...] ומעתה אליכם הכהנים המצוה הזאת לסמכו ולשמחו שבע שמחות בכסף מלא [...] למען ישוב בהר ה' יראה להשגיח על בני ביתו כי כלם עיניהם תלויות אחר השגחתו ית' [יתברך] ובשכר הנה אלדינו זה עומד אחר כתלנו משגיח להניח ברכה באסמיכם, ישלח עזרכם מקדש ומציון יסעד אתכם, ועיניכם תראינה ירושלם נוה שאנן וארמון על משפטו כנפשכם, וכו'.

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A plea in the matter of a captive who is imprisoned we know not where.

[To the one who is] a flowing spring, who knows the will of the Highest, a fountain of wisdom,¹ [- - - - -] a man of God who is called holy,² who is an exemplar for the nations.³ People come to him from the ends of the earth so that he can inform them about the laws of God and His teachings,⁴ because his waters flow from the Temple,⁵ the waters of Torah and mitzva, which it is a mitzva to provide to the nation [- - - - -]. I speak of the wise man, entirely perfect, the esteemed rabbi, may God save and keep him, may his name live forever, [and may he live] to a ripe old age.⁶ May he forever dwell in stillness and quiet before God.⁷ May his throne be established forever⁸ as the moon is established forever,⁹ he and his sons in the

¹ A combination of Proverbs 18:4 and Numbers 24:16 (where Balaam declares: “The prophecy of the one who hears God’s speech, who knows the will of the Highest, and beholds visions from the Almighty”).

² A reference to Isaiah 4:3: “And those who remain in Zion and are left in Jerusalem shall be called holy.”

³ Based on Isaiah 11:10.

⁴ “The laws of God and His teachings” is based on Exodus 18:16.

⁵ Based on Ezekiel 47:12: “Because the water for them flows from the Temple. Their fruit will serve for food and their leaves for healing.”

⁶ Based on Psalms 71:18.

⁷ A combination of Isaiah 30:15 and Psalms 61:8.

⁸ Proverbs 29:14.

⁹ Psalms 89:38: “as the moon is established forever.”

midst of the people of Israel,¹⁰ now and forever, with eternal life. Amen, eternally, selah, and forever .

This is to call your eminence's attention to the plight of the elderly woman so-and-so, mother of so-and-so. She came before us, her cheeks wet with tears, like water cascading down a slope.¹¹ She cries and causes others to cry with her, due to her desire to see her son so-and-so. A number of years ago, he set out somewhere, and she did not know where he was and whether he was alive or dead.¹² Her soul was embittered¹³ as no one could even tell her where he was headed. Recently, she was told by someone that her son has been detained and imprisoned by a Jew to whom he owed a certain amount and had to serve him for free until he repays the debt. Therefore, we implore you, dignitaries, kings, and princes,¹⁴ to rescue a prisoner from confinement,¹⁵ to stand at the right hand of Moshe¹⁶ and save him. Do not rest¹⁷ until you have sent this young man [money] to redeem him from there and raise him up post haste.¹⁸ This will comfort his elderly mother whose soul lies prostrate in the dust¹⁹ and is in constant pain due to their separation, for her soul is bound up with his soul.²⁰ This will be credited to you as righteousness,²¹ for you will revive her soul in the midst of Jerusalem.²²

¹⁰ Based on Deuteronomy 17:20.

¹¹ A combination of Lamentations 1:2 and Micah 1:4.

¹² The Hebrew words for "alive" and "dead" have quotation marks inserted mid-word, evidently to indicate a reference to the story of the living child and the dead child in the famous story of Solomonic justice (I Kings 3:16-28).

¹³ Based on II Kings 4:27, where the young son of the Shunamite woman is resurrected by Elisha.

¹⁴ Based on Babylonian Talmud, Megillah 12a.

¹⁵ Isaiah 42:7.

¹⁶ A combination of Isaiah 63:12 and Psalms 109:31, and also possible indication that the name of the captive is Moshe.

¹⁷ Literally: do not be silent.

¹⁸ Based on Isaiah 8:1.

¹⁹ Based on Psalms 44:26.

²⁰ Based on Genesis 44:30.

²¹ Based on Genesis 15:6.

²² Based on Psalms 116:19.

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לחלות פני איש על שבוי שנשבה ולא נודע מקומו

נחל נובע יודע דעת עליון מקור החכמה [---- ---] איש אלדים קדוש יאמר לו העומד לנס עמ[ים] אליו יבאו מאפסי ארץ להגיד להם את חקי האלדים ואת תורותיו, כי מימיו מן המקדש הם יוצאים, מי התורה והמצוה, והמצוה להשקות העם [--- ---] ה"ה [הלא הוא] החכם השלם בכל שלמות כה"ר [כבוד הרב] נר"ו [נטריה רחמנא ופרקיה] יהי שמו לעולם גם עד זקנה ושיבה בשובה ונחת ישב עולם לפני אלדים כסאו לעד יכון כירח יכון עולם הוא ובניו בקרב ישראלמעתה ועד עולם חיים עד עולם אנס"ו [אמן נצח סלה ועד].

הן זאת לשמיע [להשמיע] במרום קדשם כי באה לפנינו הזקנה פ' [לונית] אם פ' [לוני] ודמעתה על לחיה כמים נגרים במורד, בוכה ומבכה אחרים עמה על תשוקת ראות פני בנה פ', כי זה כמה שנים שהלך לו למקום פ' ושוב לא נודע לה מקומו איה, אם מ"ת אם ח"י, ונפשה מרה לה כי אין מגיד לה אנה פניו מועדות. וכעת הגד הוגד לה מפי פ' שהוא עצור וכלוא בשבי ביד איש יהודי על סך מה, ונתחייב לשרתו בחנם עד שיפרע לו הסך הנז' [כר]. לכן בבעו במטו מנייכו אפרכי מלכי ונסיכי להוציא ממסגר אסיר, שיעמדו לימין משה, שיצילו אותו, ואל יתנו דומי עד שישלחו ל[ב] חור הנז' לפדותו

משם ולהעלות חש בז לנחם לב אמו הזקנה, כי שחה לעפר נפשה וכל ימיה במכאובים על פרידתו, כי נפשה קשורה בנפשו, וצדקה תחשב להם, כי מחיים את נפשה בתוככי ירושלים.

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To you, the holy community, may God watch over you, shalom. We have seen the poverty of this man who will be visiting you, the hunger in his home, and his helplessness, and that his strength has given out. His young lions lack and go hungry,¹ his children cry out to God, wandering without food² or clothing, and without protection against the cold.³ Additionally, there are many creditors hounding him for money, chasing after him and pressuring him, searching for him on a daily basis in every nook and cranny, looking to shackle him and cause him grief as in the wilderness.⁴ When he called out to us, we paid heed⁵ and helped to the best of our ability, in accordance with God's hand that has been good to us.⁶ But we are unable to take care of all his needs and meet his requests for whatever he lacks,⁷ as the blanket is stretched too thin,⁸ and a single handful of food does not

¹ Based on Psalms 34:11, meaning his young children.

² Based on Job 38:41.

³ Based on Job 24:7.

⁴ Based on Psalms 78:40.

⁵ Based on Exodus 22:26.

⁶ Based on Ezra 8:18.

⁷ Based on Deuteronomy 15:8.

⁸ Isaiah 28:20.

satisfy a lion, and a pit will not be filled up by rainwater alone.⁹ When he saw that he had no luck in this city and was unable to manage,¹⁰ he decided to change locations, going here and there,¹¹ a restless wanderer on earth,¹² in hopes of finding favor with God. Therefore, we said: Let us send a letter telling you about him,¹³ so that when he arrives in your holy camp, you will bestow upon him some of the goodness God has granted you. Treat him well, give him what he needs, and pour overflowing blessings upon him.¹⁴ Open up your hands wide for him¹⁵ and give him generously¹⁶ to the best of your ability. Stretch out your arm to gather in wanderers, and to bring the downtrodden poor into your home.¹⁷ For he is our brother, our own flesh and blood, and you must not turn away from him.¹⁸ [If you help him] you will live securely,¹⁹ enjoying an abundance of peace.²⁰ Through charity you will be established,²¹ and by heaven you will be blessed.

⁹ Babylonian Talmud, Berakhot 3b.

¹⁰ Based on Genesis 32:26 (literally: he could not prevail).

¹¹ Based on II Kings 5:25.

¹² Genesis 4:14.

¹³ Based on Ezra 4:18.

¹⁴ Based on Malachi 3:10.

¹⁵ Based on Deuteronomy 15:8.

¹⁶ Based on Deuteronomy 15:14.

¹⁷ Based on Isaiah 58:7.

¹⁸ A combination of Genesis 37:27 and Isaiah 58:7.

¹⁹ Based on Leviticus 25:18.

²⁰ Based on Psalms 37:11.

²¹ Based on Isaiah 54:14.

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Individual emissaries from Eretz Israel (שליחים לעצמם) and letters written for them

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Jerusalem, The National Library of Israel, Ktiv Project, Ms. Heb. 8°61, system no. 990000434660205171, Correspondence from Jerusalem in the 17th Century, letter no. 165, fol. 196 (digitized fol. 103).

אליכם ק"ק יצ"ו שלום. ראה ראינו את עוני האיש הזה ההולך לקראתכם ואת רעבון ביתו וקוצר ידו, וכי אפס כחו כפיריו רשו ורעבו וילדיו אל אל ישועו, יתעו לבלי אוכל ושמלה ואין כסות בקרה, ונוסף עליו כי רבו הנוגשים והנושים, אצים רצים לוחצים אותו, מחפשים אחריו בחורים ובסדקים מדי יום ביומו לתת בכבל רגלו ולהעציבו כישימון. והיה כי צעק אלינו ושמענו ועשינו אליו כפי כחינו וכיד ה' הטובה עלינו, אך כי לא נוכל למלא את כל חפצו ולהפיק את שאלתו די מחסורו אשר יחסר לו, כי קצר המצע מהשתרע ואין הקומץ משביע את הארי ואין הבור מתמלא מחולייתו. ובראותו דביש ליה בהאי מתא [=וכשראה שאין לו מזל בעיר הזאת] ולא יכול לו, נתן אל לבו לשנות את מקומו ללכת אנה ואנה, נע ונד בארץ, אולי ירצה ה' לו. על כן אמרנו: נגלה אצלכם בהדא נשתונא דאנן שלחין קדמכון [באגרת זו שאנו שולחים לכם] והיה בבואו אצל מחנה קדושתכם ופקדתם אותו מן הטוב אשר ייטיב ה' אליכם והטבתם עמו ותפיקו חפצו להריק עליו ברכה עד בלי די ופתוח תפתחו לו את ידכם הרחבה והענק תעניקוהו די כחכם וזרועכם הנטויה לקבץ נדחים, ועניים מרודים תביא בית, כי אחינו בשרנו הוא [וממ]נו אל תתעלמו. ואתם תשבו בטח תתענגו על רוב שלום בצדקה תכוננו ומן השמים תבורכו.